So, here I was, confident yet anxious of the static test results. They ran the test by firing the engine and slowly increasing the operating pressure. At around 56 bars, Viking was showing a tendency of instability. Dorville was shocked. Ayyappan Pillai and I were right. The French were impressed. Soon, I would be invited to the high table of Review Critique Design.

It is another matter that the French went ahead and produced more than thirty Viking engines with the low margin of stability since they had mass fabricated combustion chambers, before our theory was validated. The Arianne vehicle, which used the first set of Viking engines, were designed with four first stage engines and one second stage engine, which meant the rocket used five Viking engines for a launch. The first launch (L-01) was a success, the second was a failure because of the low stability margin in one of the four engines of the first stage. We were getting validated, again.

The French held a review committee that discussed the low stability margin. After long discussions, the committee decided to discard the more than twenty engines with the old specifications, and improve upon the safety margin to make the Arianne flight more reliable. It was now, in 1981 that ISRO had developed a 350 kg satellite, and Ariane offered to launch it free of cost. It was a win-win for both. The French wanted a payload to test the efficacy of the improved Viking engine, India needed a rocket to take its communication satellite to space. Since it was an experiment, technically speaking, the French offered a free ride. The satellite came to be known as APPLE (Ariane Passenger Payload Experiment). It was a success.

I am not sure if the French would acknowledge that we had contributed to the improvement in the safety margin of the Viking combustion chamber, but I was happy that it got me into the Review Critique Design of SEP. Here everything was on a need-to-know basis. You just could not shoot questions to enrich your knowledge. You could make observations and, if vital to the point being discussed, air your views. It was not a place to clarify your doubts. But that wasn't a problem. Mere observation of the RCD proceedings gave me invaluable insights. And this changed the way I perceived certain things, from as simple a process as recording minutes of a meeting, to quality control.